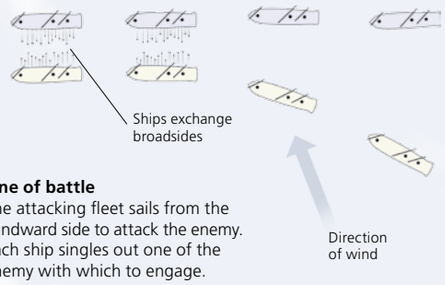
# NAVAL TACTICS IN THE AGE OF NELSON

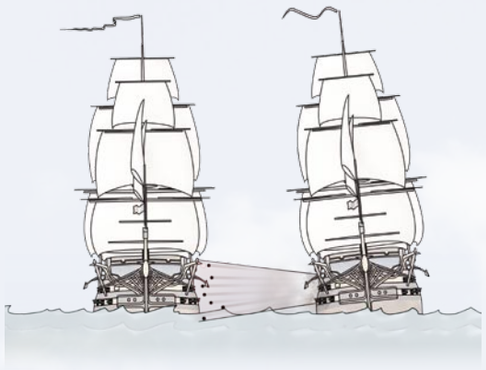
Royal Navy warships often departed from the formal tradition of fighting in line of battle – when two hostile fleets sailing in the same direction formed up abreast of each other to exchange broadsides (volleys fired by all the guns on one side of the ship). Nelson and captains who followed his ideas preferred to cut through the enemy line to fight in what Nelson called a "pell-mell" fashion. They could do this because of the high standard of their seamanship. In a sea battle, the ship's guns could be loaded with various kinds of shot: large round shot (the traditional cannonball) to inflict damage on the enemy's hull, chain shot (two smaller projectiles linked by a chain) for attacking a ship's rigging and spars, and canister (a container of small shot used as an anti-personnel weapon).

## Broadsides

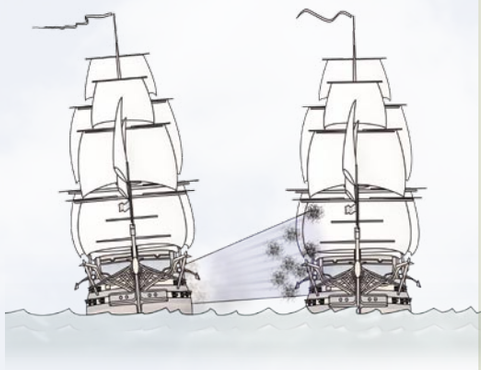
The classical form of naval engagement throughout the 18th century was based on the line of battle. The attacking fleet bore down on the enemy to fire broadsides. Well-trained gun crews could time the moment of firing a broadside, using the rolling motion of the ship on the waves to direct their fire at the enemy hull or upwards at its sails and rigging.




**Line of battle**
The attacking fleet sails from the windward side to attack the enemy. Each ship singles out one of the enemy with which to engage.



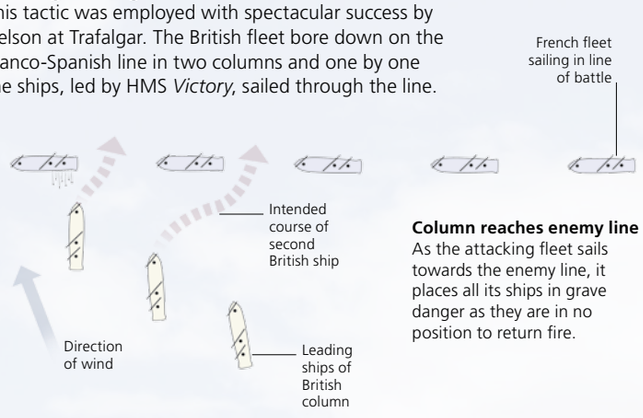
**Firing on the downward roll**
This tactic was used by captains keen to win the encounter. Round shot was directed at the enemy's hull, causing destruction and death on the gun decks.



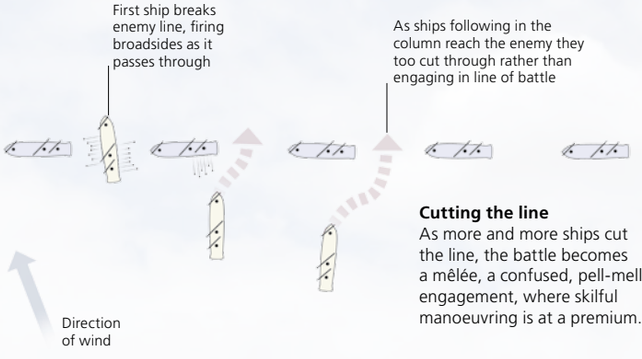
**Firing on the upward roll**
When a captain wanted to disable the other ship so it could not give chase, he directed chain shot and canister upwards to damage the sails and rigging.

## Cutting through the line

This tactic was employed with spectacular success by Nelson at Trafalgar. The British fleet bore down on the Franco-Spanish line in two columns and one by one the ships, led by HMS *Victory*, sailed through the line.




**Column reaches enemy line**
As the attacking fleet sails towards the enemy line, it places all its ships in grave danger as they are in no position to return fire.




**Cutting the line**
As more and more ships cut the line, the battle becomes a mêlée, a confused, pell-mell engagement, where skilful manoeuvring is at a premium.

**Raking fire**
As a ship cuts through the enemy line, it can unleash a broadside in either direction while the enemy is unable to return fire.

